

Practical : 4	Implementation and Time analysis of factorial program using iterative and recursive method
Date : 15/07/2026	

Aim: To implement and compare **iterative and recursive methods for calculating the factorial number.**

Objective :-To implement programs to calculate the factorial of a given number in C++ using both iterative and recursive methods, and to analyze and compare their respective time and space complexities.

A. Iterative Factorial Algorithm

1. Start.
2. Read n.
3. Initialize result = 1.
4. Run a loop from 1 to n.
5. Multiply result by the current value.
6. Return the result.
7. Stop.

B. Recursive Factorial Algorithm

1. Start.
2. Read n.
3. If $n \leq 1$, return 1.
4. Otherwise calculate $n \times \text{factorial}(n-1)$.
5. Continue until the base case is reached.
6. Return the result.
7. Stop.

Program:

```
#include <iostream>

using namespace std;

// 1. Iterative Method

long long factorialIterative(int n) {
```

```
        long long result = 1;

        for (int i = 1; i <= n; i++) {

            result *= i;

        }

        return result;

    }

// 2. Recursive Method

long long factorialRecursive(int n) {

    // Base Case

    if (n <= 1) {

        return 1;

    }

    // Recursive Case

    return n * factorialRecursive(n - 1);

}

int main() {

    int num;

    cout << "Enter a positive integer: ";

    cin >> num;
```

```
        if (num < 0) {  
            cout << "Factorial of a negative number is not defined."  
                << endl;  
        }  
        else {  
            // Iterative Method  
            long long iterativeResult =  
                factorialIterative(num);  
            cout << "\n--- Iterative Method ---" << endl;  
            cout << "Factorial of " << num  
                << " is: " << iterativeResult << endl;  
            // Recursive Method  
            long long recursiveResult =  
                factorialRecursive(num);  
            cout << "\n--- Recursive Method ---" << endl;  
            cout << "Factorial of " << num  
                << " is: " << recursiveResult << endl;  
        }  
        return 0;  
    }  
}
```

Output:

```
Output

Enter a positive integer: 10

--- Iterative Method ---
Factorial of 10 is: 3628800

--- Recursive Method ---
Factorial of 10 is: 3628800

=== Code Execution Successful ===
```

Analysis:

Time Complexity Analysis

Let n be the input number for which we need to calculate the factorial.

Iterative Method:

- The iterative function executes a simple for loop that runs exactly n times to multiply the values from **1 to n** . Since there are no nested steps, the execution time grows linearly with the input size.

Time Complexity = $O(n)$

Recursive Method:

- The recursive function calls itself continuously, decremented by 1 at each step:
- **$T(n) = T(n - 1) + O(1)$**
- This sequence continues until it hits the **base case ($n \leq 1$)**. This creates a total chain of n recursive function calls, resulting in a linear growth rate.

Time Complexity = $O(n)$

Space Complexity Analysis

Iterative Method:

- The loop uses only a few fixed-size scalar variables (result, i) to run. The amount of memory occupied stays completely constant and independent of the input value n.

Space Complexity = $O(1)$

Recursive Method:

- Every time a function calls itself, a new stack frame is pushed onto the system call stack to store the current state and return address. For an input of size n, the system must hold n active stack frames simultaneously before hitting the base case and unwinding.

Space Complexity = $O(n)$

Conclusion :-

While both methods successfully calculate the factorial of a number in linear time $O(n)$, their system overhead profiles are vastly different:

1. The **Iterative Method** is highly memory efficient. It works with a constant auxiliary footprint of $O(1)$ space, making it safe from stack exhaustion limits.
2. The **Recursive Method** is mathematically expressive and maps directly to the recursive definition of factorials. However, it requires linear auxiliary memory space of $O(n)$ due to the call stack overhead. For large inputs, this makes recursion prone to a **stack overflow** crash.